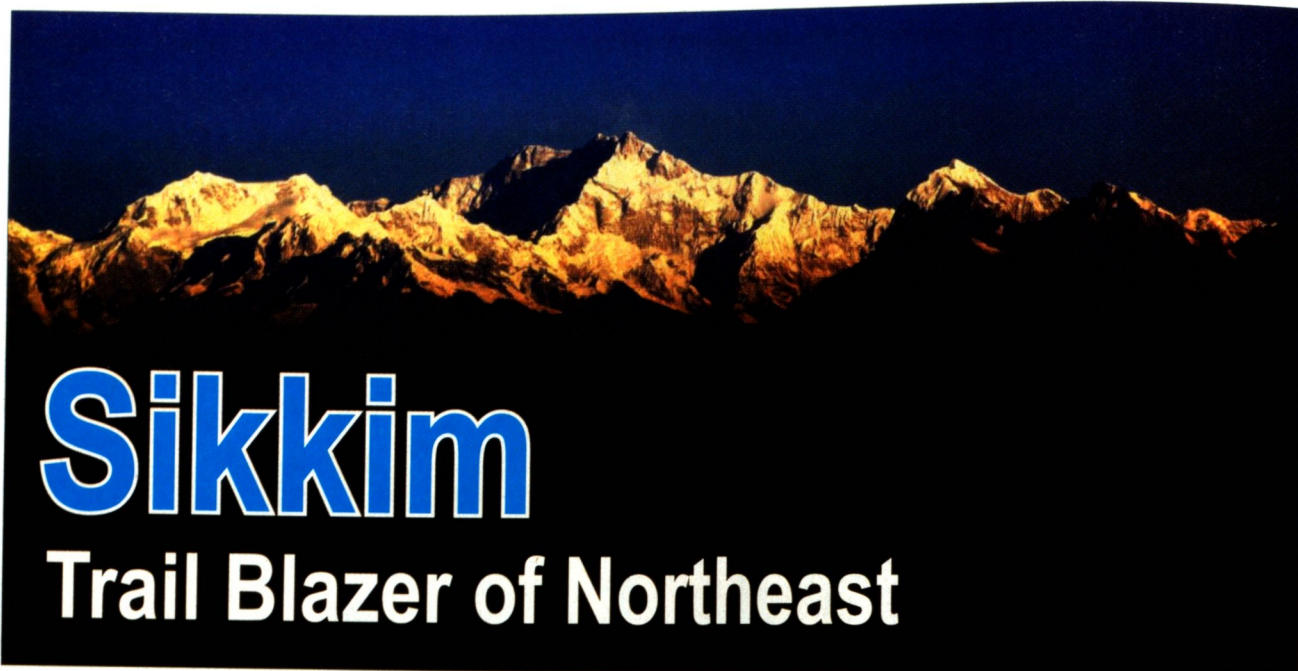




Sikkim

Trail Blazer of Northeast

The newest entrant to the North East, Sikkim, with its startlingly beautiful landscape is seductive in its charm. The crowning glory of Sikkim is Mount Khangchendzonga, the third highest mountain in the world. The Teesta and Rangeet rivers embellish its natural beauty and the profusion of flora and fauna make Sikkim a unique destination.

But this scenic splendour is not the only reason why Sikkim is on a high. Today, Sikkim is a model state of the Northeast, its achievements worth emulating. Its income growth rate is the fifth highest in the country, literacy rate is 82 per cent, crime is virtually non-existent in the state and it ranks third in best performance in Panchayati Raj. Sikkim has also ranked first among 12 eastern states for its overall performance.

It would not be an overstatement to say that the person instrumental in bringing development and peace to the region is Chief Minister Pawan Chamling, who led the Sikkim Democratic Party to victory in 1994 and has been governing Sikkim ever since. Pawan Chamling's victorious march continues to go from strength to strength, creating momentum for progress in the state.

Chamling's avowed ideological revolution was aimed to change the people's mindset and empower them fully. When the SDF government took over the reins of government almost 14 years ago, the state was in a financial mess. It was gradually brought out of the dire situation by dint of stringent financial discipline and a creative approach.

Great socio-economic changes have also taken place in these past nearly 14 years with the political demands of each and every ethnic group having been fulfilled. As per the calculation

made by State authorities based on NSS data per capita value of the Scheduled Tribe (Bhutias & Lepchas) in Sikkim is Rs. 71,700 as against national average of the STs of Rs. 30,000. The per capita asset value in general of the Sikkimese population is Rs. 60,000 as against the national average of Rs. 40,000.

Pawan Chamling has worked with single-minded dedication to give the people a responsive, pro-poor and people centric government. Today, with benefits drawn from such an all-embracing and liberal approach,

Sikkim has become a land of opportunities. The government has created a positive atmosphere for trade, commercial and social ventures in the state. The development agenda is being fashioned with an eye on certain long-term goals that Sikkim hopes to achieve by the year 2015. Among other goals, this includes the alleviation of all poverty, reducing unemployment, attaining 100 percent literacy; facilitating high levels of social justice; making health care accessible to all and facilitating inclusive democracy.



Journey towards emotional integration

Sikkim joined the Indian Union as recently as in 1975, nearly three decades after Independence and its bid to assimilate with the mainstream was as challenged by time as it was by distance from the heartland. Pawan Chamling, a nationalist to the core, has always believed that people should aspire for emotional and intellectual integration for a stronger and prosperous country and the State Government has worked consistently towards this end and with much success. In recognition of his endeavor to ensure that Sikkim's integration into the mainstream of national life is nurtured with sensitivity, the Chief Minister was given the Bharat Shiromani award.

The state government has diligently applied itself to arrest the isolation syndrome that is often in the minds of the people of the region and has worked towards bringing them fully into the main stream of the nation, even while safeguarding the distinctive ethnic and cultural identity of